UNIT 15

The Marathas

Learning Objectives

To acquire knowledge in

- Conditions that facilitated the rise of Marathas
- Shivaji's contribution to the establishment of Maratha kingdom
- Shivaji's administrative system
- Peshwa rule and administration
- Role of Maratha in Tamilnadu with special reference to Serfoji II

Introduction

The Marathas played a major role in the decline of Mughal power. Under the dynamic leadership of Shivaji, they posed a strong challenge to Mughal power during the 1670s. By the middle of the 18th century, they had succeeded in displacing Mughal power in central India. Nayak rule ended in 1674 in Thanjavur, when the Maratha General Venkoji (half brother of Shivaji) leading the Bijapur forces invaded Thanjavur and succeeded in establishing Maratha rule in the Tamil region. Maratha rule in Thanjavur which started from 1674 continued until the death of Serfoji II in 1832.

15.1 Causes of the Rise of the Marathas

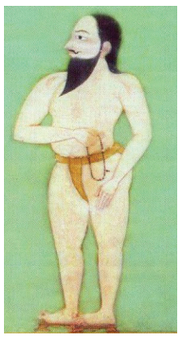
(a) Physical features and Nature of the People

The region of the Marathas consisted of a narrow strip of land called Konkan. Its precipitous mountains, inaccessible valleys and impregnable hill-forts were most favourable for military defence. The Marathas claimed a long tradition of military prowess and prided themselves on their loyalty, courage, discipline, cunningness, and endurance. They had earlier served under the Bahmani Sultans and later, after its disintegration, under the Sultans of Ahmednagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Bidar and Berar.

Marathas avoided direct battles with the Mughal armies that were equipped with strong cavalry and deadly cannons. "Guerrilla warfare" was their strength. They possessed the ability to plan and execute the surprise lightning attacks at night. Further, they exhibited skills to change their tactics according to the battle situation without waiting for orders from a superior officer.

(b) Bhakti Movement and its Impact

The spread of the Bhakti movement inculcated the spirit of oneness among the Marathas. Tukaram, Ramdas, and Eknath were the leading lights of the movement. The hymns of the Bhakti saints were sung in Marathi and they created a bond among people across the society.



Ramdas

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